IT **WAS A SWELTERING SATURDAY IN PATNA ON MAY 3**, but the heat wasn't just from the rising mercury in the summer. At the Miller High School Ground in the centre of the city, Tejashwi Yadav was whipping up some serious passion of his own. The Rashtriya Janata Dal leader was addressing a rally—the *'Ati-Pichhda Jagao, Tejashwi Sarkar Banao* (Wake Up the EBCs, Elect a Tejashwi government)' rally organised by his party's EBC (Extremely Backward Classes) cell. "No EBC community has prospered, while Nitish has flourished," Tejashwi thundered, mounting a salvo against his once grand ally—Janata Dal (United) supremo and Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar. He promised them jobs and safety; freedom from crimes and criminals too. "*Jo apraadh karega, gareebon ka shoshan karega, apamanit karega, usko main jail bhijwaunga* (Whoever commits a crime, exploits or insults the poor, I will send them to jail)," he vowed, positioning himself in just that single sentence as a bulwark against injustice as well as indignity.



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ALL FOR ONE, ONE... Tejashwi Yadav speaks at the RJD's 'Ati-Pichhda Jagao' rally in Patna, May 3

Just four days earlier, on April 29, Tejashwi had been addressing an altogether different assembly—of the economically forward Vaishya or trader community. The occasion was Bhama Shah Jayanti, and the state RJD office had organised a function to honour the 16th-century merchant hero. "Your enterprise has driven Bihar's growth," he told them, "yet the current regime never recognised your contributions." It was a pivot for a party that has seldom shown any affection for the merchant community. Tejashwi reminded the gathering how, during his brief tenure as deputy chief minister between August 2022 and January 2024, he had brought in "Rs 50,000 crore in fresh investment" and delivered "half a million jobs". The ground laid thus, Tejashwi got down to business. "If you walk one step with me, I will walk four with you." The audience expressed its approval, with a giant burst of applause.

Tejashwi's two speeches, delivered in quick succession, are of a piece with a strategy forged out of hard electoral arithmetic. In the 2020 Bihar assembly election, the *mahagathbandhan*, or the grand alliance, a coalition of the RJD, Congress and the Left parties, had won 110 seats in the 243-member House. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA), comprising chiefly of the BJP and the JD(U), eked out a victory with 125 seats, despite a vote share that was just 0.03 percentage points higher than that of the rival formation. While the actual difference in votes was just 11,150, the real margin, as it turned out, lay in the unaligned and disaffected segments that neither bloc fully commanded. And it is into this untapped reservoir that Tejashwi is now casting his net.

GETTING HIS EBC RIGHT

The EBCs are 113 marginalised castes that constitute more than 36 per cent of Bihar's population, according to the latest caste-based survey. Given their fragmented nature, they have never had the social clout of dominant OBC castes like the Yadavs—who account for 14 per cent of the state's population—yet exercise outsize influence at the hustings thanks to their numbers. They have been an inalienable part of Nitish's support base, ever since the nine-time chief minister granted them 20 per cent reservations in panchayat bodies back in 2006. Tejashwi is now trying to chip away at that support base, and attempting to forge a bond with voters who almost never pick the RJD as first choice in Bihar's political power play. His current efforts may not consolidate every EBC vote, but they could be enough to tilt the scales.

TEJASHWI WILL HAVE TO BE CAREFUL THAT THE PUSH TO WIDEN THE RJD VOTER BASE DOES NOT CREATE RESENTMENT AMONG HIS CORE MUSLIM-YADAV VOTE BANK

This will not be the first time that Tejashwi has tried to broaden his outreach, but while the efforts have resulted in impressive tallies, they have failed